

American Gov./ Economics





About the Course

Students spend a term learning the structure of our local and state governments, then turn to key primary source documents related to our government before ending the year with an introduction to economics, focusing on the history of money, the banking system, and personal finance.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Citizenship: Grade 8 (U.S.)



Placement & Combining Tips

If a student hasn't studied the Constitution, consider having them take the 7th-grade government course first.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
8	American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 1 time/week 30 min	Dollars and Sense: A Kid's Guide to Using - Not Losing - Money Reading PDF

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Citizenship: Grade 8 (U.S.)				
Ethics: Part 2 Community Read Alouds: Grades 1-12		American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 Current Events: Grades 5-8		Plutarch: Grades 6-8



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Citizenship: Grade 8 (U.S.)

☐ Make sure your student sets up a Citizenship Notebook. They will need a 3-ring binder, lined notebook paper, and 5 Tabbed Dividers. You can read more about how to set one up and suggestions for various sections in the document in Quick Links.

☐ As desired, plan for a read aloud time. Suggestions are provided in the Community Read Aloud Quick Link, but local favorites are highly recommended whenever possible.

☐ Make a Calendar of Events for Current Events lessons by drawing a calendar grid in a

notebook (or print a blank calendar from the internet).

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

☐ Save or print the Reading PDF. (See Quick Links)



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8



Dollars and Sense: A Kid's Guide to Using - Not Losing - Money



Reading PDF



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

∞ [Grade 8 Reading PDF: State & Local Gov](#)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

How To Teach



Prepare

Plutarch: Teachers will find it helpful to preread the entire Life first, and then preread the day's passage before each lesson. Mark any passages that should be omitted due to content. (In Anne White's Plutarch Project books, the recommended source for this course, objectionable content has already been omitted.)

Current Events: Preview the news source for suitability.

Most other citizenship topics don't require additional prep.



Recap

Connect back to the previous lesson. (Optional for Current Events).



Introduce

For news sources, show students how to scan the headlines to get an overview first and then choose a story to read.

For Plutarch or other books: Use a picture, a map, or an engaging question to prepare students to receive the story as relevant. You may talk about one or two unfamiliar words that will be crucial to understanding. It is not necessary to cover all unfamiliar words.



Read

Read the selection assigned or the news story chosen. For rich, dense, or more challenging books such as *Ourselves* and *Plutarch*, it is a good idea to read them aloud. Have students keep an eye out for things to add to their Citizenship Notebook, *Book of Centuries*, and/or *Commonplace book*.



Narrate

Have the students narrate orally or in writing.



Discuss

Give students an opportunity to share their thoughts on the story and any connections made. For current events, look up where events occurred on a map and ask questions to help students discern the quality of the piece. (e.g., Are there sources cited? Is there an obvious bias? If so, what do other authors have to say on this subject? Are arguments supported by evidence? Is that evidence credible?) Consider reading an alternative perspective.



Citizenship Notebook

Have students record important ideas in their Citizenship Notebooks.

Term 1

WEEK 1

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 1

Introduction to State & Local Government

 Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

This term, we will learn about state and local governments. While we will focus on state and local government, we will sometimes reference the federal government to compare and contrast the state and local powers with federal powers.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF
Read p.2-4

→ REFLECT

Narrate. Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 2

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 2

Origins of Authority: Constitutions & Police Powers

 Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

States have two sources of authority that allow them to create and enforce laws: 1) constitutional powers, and 2) police powers. These sources of authority are the basis for the laws and regulations that states pass, as well as the authority that states grant to smaller local governments, like cities and towns.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF
Read p.5-8

→ REFLECT

Narrate. Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 3

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 3

State Constitutions

 Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

Last week, we explored sources of power for states. One of these sources is the state constitution. This week, you are going to familiarize yourself with your state's constitution.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF
Read p.9

→ REFLECT

Narrate. Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 4

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 4

State Constitutions: The Preamble

 Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

Although they do not have "legal effect," the preamble to a constitution is an important statement. This week, you will examine your state constitution's preamble and consider its importance.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF
Read p.10-13

→ REFLECT

Narrate. For your summary statement this week, analyze your state constitution's preamble as described in the Reading PDF on page 13.

Term 1

WEEK 5

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 5

State Government

Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

Today you will learn about your state government.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF

Read p.14

→ NOTEBOOK

Answer the questions about your state in your Citizenship Notebook.

WEEK 6

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 6

State Legislative Branch

Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

This week, you will review the sections of your state constitution that address the legislative branch, and look up your state government representatives.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF

Read p.15-18

→ REFLECT

Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 7

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 7

State Executive Branch

Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

This week, you will review the sections of your state constitution that address the executive branch and read about your state governor.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF

Read p.19

→ REFLECT

Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 8

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 8

State Judicial Branch

Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

This week, you will review the sections of your state constitution that address the judicial branch and read about your state's highest court.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF

Read p.20

→ REFLECT

Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 9

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 9

Local Governments

Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

You have read about the Federal government and the state government. Today, you will look at local government. Local governments are a paradox because we most often forget that they exist, while they often have the most direct impact on our daily lives. This week we will look at what they are and where local governments derive their authority (hint, it's not the Constitution).

→ READING

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#) QR

Term 1

∞ Link: Reading PDF
Read p.21-24

→ REFLECT

Narrate. Write a summary statement or short narration describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 10

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 10

Local Governments in Action

📄 Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

This week you'll focus on looking at how local governments impact our daily lives by reading some current events. Your Reading PDF includes several suggested articles, as well as tips for finding a good article for your local government.

→ READING

∞ Link: Reading PDF
Read p.25

→ REFLECT

Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from the article you read.

WEEK 11

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 11

Catch Up and Exploring Local Government Resources

📄 Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

This week you will learn more about your local government.

→ ASSIGNMENT

∞ Link: Reading PDF
Go to p.26-27

→ NOTEBOOK

Answer the questions about your town/county in your Citizenship Notebook.

WEEK 12

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 12

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to course.

Questions will come from:
Reading PDF

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#) 

Term 2		
WEEK 1	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 13	
WEEK 2	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 14	
WEEK 3	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 15	
WEEK 4	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 16	
WEEK 5	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 17	
WEEK 6	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 18	
WEEK 7	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 19	
WEEK 8	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 20	
WEEK 9	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 21	
WEEK 10	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 22	
WEEK 11	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 23	
WEEK 12	 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 24	

Term 3

WEEK 1

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 25

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

→ INTRO

Are you familiar with the Bible verse, "The love of money is a root of all kinds of evil" (I Timothy 6:10)? What do you think that means, and how have you seen that truth play out? This term, we will be studying economics, which has to do with money and the way a country uses and produces goods and services.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Introduction ix-xiii "Bread, Dough." - "dollars and cents." , as well as Ch.1, at bottom of p.8, "You've Got It and I Want It: The Law of Supply and Demand"

- How does money help the economy, and how does greed hurt the economy?

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

∞ Video Link: What is Supply and Demand?

- Explain the economic principle "The Law of Supply and Demand."

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK (MAKE A SECTION IN YOUR NOTEBOOK OR BINDER CALLED ECONOMICS)

1. Make a list of the goods and services your family uses that contribute toward a healthy economy. Goods are tangible things you buy, such as clothes and food. Services are intangible and usually involve paying for a business to do something for you. Examples: haircuts, car insurance, phone service.
2. Can you think of examples that fit the economic principle of The Law of Supply and Demand? Also, make a list of items that may be in high demand or low demand depending on the time of year.

WEEK 2

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 26

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

→ RECAP

What do you remember about last week's reading?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.1 Skulls, Sheep, and Shells, p.1-9 "Have you ever" - "the ancient world."

- Why did the bartering system need to be replaced with something better?

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

∞ Image Link: Cowrie shells (used as money in ancient China)

∞ Image Link: Deerskin used as folding money (China)

∞ Image Link: Chinese paper money

∞ Image Link: Fort Knox

- Talk about the different items used before money and why they didn't work out.

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Make a timeline and draw pictures with labels to show the different mediums of exchange from ancient times to the present day. Look at p.4-5 to help you fill out the timeline. There are links to see some of the different mediums that were used.

WEEK 3

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 27

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Historical Atlas of the World

→ RECAP

What do you remember about last week's reading?

→ LOCATE

• Using the Historical Atlas of the World p.8, find Mesopotamia and Babylon. What present-day countries are located there?

- Go to p.30-31, find Jerusalem, Edessa, Antioch and Tripoli. Now, find Florence, Italy. These are places that we will read about today that have to do with an early form of banking.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.2 Worry, Worry! p.11-19, "Where do you keep" - "Hard work." In addition, read sections on p.12 "An Eye for an Eye" and p.14 "You Can't Take it With You."

- What banking practices from history are still used today?

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

∞ Image Link: The Knights Templar

- How did the Knights Templar help the Pilgrims while traveling to Jerusalem?

• IMPORTANT DATES

Founding of the order the Knights Templar (1119 AD)

Term 3

WEEK 4

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 28

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

→ RECAP

What do you remember about last week's reading?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.3 New Money for a New Nation p.21- 29

"In early America" - "finally in place." (Also, go back and read the section about Alexander Hamilton on p.22.)

- What were some reasons some people were opposed to a national bank?

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Look at the map on p.27, which shows the location of Federal Reserve Banks. What bank is your city part of? You can check out this link to see the 12 districts.

∞ Image Link: The Twelve Federal Reserve Districts

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Make a chart showing the information on p.28. You can look at these websites to find additional information such as the names of the people in charge of the different areas.

∞ Link: Federal Reserve Board

∞ Link: Comptroller of the Currency

• EXTRA HELPING

Watch this 3-minute video on this website that explains the purpose of the Federal Reserve System.

∞ **Video Link:** Purpose of Federal Reserve System

• IMPORTANT DATES

Establishment of the first national bank of the United States (1791)

The Federal Reserve Banks were established (1913)

WEEK 5

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 29

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

PREP: Print out the check template and check register.

∞ Link: Check template

∞ Link: Check register

→ RECAP

What do you remember about last week's reading?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.4 Money Comes In and Money Goes Out p.31-41 "Money and power" - "always that way."

- What happens when you write a check for more than you have in your bank account?

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Explain the graph on p.39. It is based on the idea that you have \$1000 in a savings account.

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

1. Fill out the check template and check register (bank book) and put it in your notebook.

2. Make a list of the types of bank accounts and briefly describe each one. See p.40 for more information.

WEEK 6

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 30

Materials: Dollars & Sense

→ RECAP

What did you read last time in economics?

→ INTRO

Are you familiar with the stock market? What do you know about it?

Before reading chapter 5, please read the section on p.45, "Companies for Sale", to prepare for the reading.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.5 Money Goes Away p.44-49 "Inflation. Recession." - "had to be done."

- Describe some of the events that led to the Great Depression

• IMPORTANT DATES

The Stock Market Crash (1929)

WEEK 7

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 31

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time in economics?

→ INTRO

What do you think it would be like to become the President in the middle of the Great Depression?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.5 Money Goes Away p.49-53 "Franklin Delano Roosevelt" - "the Great Recession." (You don't need to read the excerpt "Thinking about Money" on p.52. It will be read in the next lesson.)

- What are some things that President Roosevelt did to help the economy? Why did some people not agree with those actions?

• EXTRA HELPING

You can look to see what public works were created in your state as a result of the New Deal which employed thousands of people.

∞ **Link:** New Deal projects by state

• IMPORTANT DATES

New Deal programs are established by FDR (1933)

Term 3

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Make a list of some of the economic programs that were part of the New Deal. You can find the information on p.53 and at the following website.

∞ Link: New Deal Programs

WEEK 8

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 32

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time in economics?

→ INTRO

Do you know what a mortgage is? How does it help people buy houses?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.6 Money Shrinks p.55-61 "Most people " - "in the future."

- Explain what we mean by a housing bubble and how that was one of the factors that led to the Great Recession.
- On p.61, the author writes, "Once again, Keynesian economics came into play as the US government stepped in to institute large and controversial programs." Go back to p.52 and read the excerpt about the famous economist John Maynard Keynes. Discuss his theories and how they came into play during the Great Recession.

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Make a list of the ways the government stepped in to stimulate the economy during the Great Recession. You can find information in the excerpts on p.60-61.

• IMPORTANT DATES

Great Recession (December, 2007-June, 2009)

WEEK 9

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 33

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time in economics?

→ INTRO

What would life be like if everyone only bought things they could afford in cash? How could that be a good thing? How could that be a negative thing? What items might be hard to purchase?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.7 Can I Borrow Some Money? p.63-71 "In the first - " in the future."

- What are the pros and cons of using credit cards?
- What factors affect one's credit score?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Make a list of the different kinds of real estate loans and include a brief description of each.

WEEK 10

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 34

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time in Economics?

→ INTRO

Why do you think having a budget is a wise financial practice?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Ch.8 Where Did My Money Go? p.73-76 "Money is - "paying the bills."

- What is the difference between needs and wants and how does that affect a budget?
- Many people suggest three categories for budgeting—spending, saving, and giving. What do you think about those 3 categories, and how can you go about implementing that?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Practice putting together a budget. Use the example on p.74 and create a chart in your notebook. If you don't have your own money or expenses, you can try to put one together to show the expenses of an average household and see what kind of income you would need to cover those expenses.

WEEK 11

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 35

Materials: Dollars & Sense, Citizenship notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time in Economics?

→ INTRO

Do you know how much debt the U.S. has? Take a guess. You can find the answer on this website:

Term 3

∞ Link: National Debt

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. Ch.8 Where Did My Money Go? p.77-86
 2. Read the excerpts on p.78 and 82
 3. Read the conclusion, p.85-86 "It's not just" - "no matter what."
- Why do you think it is so hard to balance the national budget?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Make a list of some of the items that the federal government spends money on. Make a list of ways the government receives money (revenue). Try to brainstorm by yourself and then you can use these websites to find more information.

∞ Link: Government Spending

∞ Link: Sources of Federal Revenue

WEEK 12

30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 36

📄 Materials: Dollars & Sense

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to course.

Questions will come from:
Dollars & Sense

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

Examination

- Term 1** · Describe your state government as it is created by your state constitution. Include 1) what the different branches are, 2) the powers that the different branches have, and 3) if your constitution had a preamble, what problems or goals the preamble tried to address. OR Describe the differences between the federal government, your state government, and your local government.
- Term 2** · Place Holder
- Term 3** · Dollars & Sense: Tell what you know about the formation of the national banking system OR Tell what you know about the services banks offer.